investments in the city by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who is seeking re-election to the Lok Sabha from here. On my first evening, returning to Godowlia Chowk from the Ganga Aarti on the river, a pickpocket steals my mobile phone. I go late at night to report the theft at the local police chowki and learn that mine is one of a dozen odd such thefts reported daily.

But the morning starts afresh; over the next two weeks, as I ease myself into the rhythms of the city and talk to a wide range of people, other aspects of Varanasi emerge to soften my first impressions.

Varanasi's present is even harder to reconcile with its ancient past—a city of gardens and groves; mini lakes, lotus ponds and kunds; ashrams and hermitages—only faint traces of which remain in isolated pockets. Long ago, its 'groves, streams, and pools provided a beautiful setting for temples and ashrams', wrote historian Diana Eck in her acclaimed account, *Banaras: City of Light* (1982). 'Here teachers could gather their students, yogis could practice their yoga, and ascetics and hermits could find a place for their disciplines.' Even in the late eighteenth century, Varanasi's riverfront 'was a long spectacular bluff crowned with trees and a few prominent temples'.[2] Most of the densely crowded cement buildings that now line the riverfront arose in the last two or three hundred years.

Varanasi brims with religious mythologies. It is claimed to be 'the place where the linga of Shiva was first established and worshipped on earth' and is now Shiva's permanent home. He dwells 'not only in the city's great temples, but in the very ground and substance of the place itself'.[3] Varanasi's mystique has long attracted foreigners; many have left vivid accounts of the city. It is also associated with famous natives and sojourners like the Buddha, Jain Tirthankaras, Dhanvantari, Sushruta, Patanjali, Sankara, Ramanuja, Kabir, Ravidas, Tulsidas, Nanak, Lakshmibai, Annie Besant, Premchand, Malviya and Radhakrishnan.

But 'timeless', a favourite trope of past travellers for Varanasi, now feels dated. As in much of India, the city's culture and ethos are changing fast. Old pillars of its economy are crumbling. Its weaving industry, which sustains nearly a quarter of the city—more Muslims than Hindus—is shrinking. Most weavers, known for their exquisite Banarasi silk sarees, are poor and typically work with a couple of looms set up in tiny spaces at home. Power looms have now mostly replaced handlooms, though some